

The Sociological Imagination written by C. Wright Mills in 1959 was an exposition on how our individual private lives operate within the broader social context. In the first chapter, he argued and expounded on how the individual and society at large are inevitably shaped by its culture, geography, and most importantly, history. Similarly, his elaboration on intellectual craftsmanship explains how every individual actively and passively partake in the preservation and development of these three domains. Consequently, it creates a cycle that makes human experience meaningful and holistic. Meanwhile, the study on Altruism: The Importance of Being Asked. The Rescue of Jews in Nazi Europe presented and analyzed how the cultural value of altruism was able to save lives during one of the most gruesome epochs in world history – the annihilation of Jewish people in Germany.

The Individual is a Reflection of the Society

Aristotle said that humans are political animals. What separates them from other living organisms is their capacity to think. With this great ability for rationality, it can be said that humans are the ones who interpret society. Our interpretation of the world allows us not just to comprehend the intricacies of living, but also decide on the fate and direction of society. And with that, the individual is the reflection of society. Although every individual is different from one another, it is not to say that our experiences do not have similarities or at the very least have connections. This is because we possess the same ability to think creatively. This creative thinking is demonstrated through the stockpile of research (knowledge) we conduct where we systematically study a phenomenon and create meanings out of this human experience. Even though modern day research has a particular way of execution, it is no different with the basic taking down of notes. As a matter of fact, knowledge production starts with writing down your ideas and the problems you encounter.

A researcher develops his research topic by tapping into his curiosities. He uses the ideas in his mind that is based on the questions or problems he has for living and interacting everyday with his environment and the people around him. A great demonstration of human intellectual craftsmanship was the study conducted by Federico Varese and Meir Yaish where they delved into altruistic attitudes and behaviors. Altruism is defined in the study as “the ability to help others and show an interest in their well-being (Varese & Yaish, 1998).” It began with the problem of discovering the nature of altruism – whether its innate and universal (pure) or motivational (impure) – in times of crisis like the extermination of Jews in Germany. Then, since research is a systematic study, he develops his own methods for which is crucial for the generation of his

conclusions and answers to the problems. Going back to Varese and Yaish, they designed their methodology in a way that is apt to their (research) problems. Since the focus of the study is on a past event, the researchers decided to perform a regression analysis that analyzed all possible circumstances of altruism during that time period. To help in making generalizable conclusions, they included data sets from previously done studies for data analysis. From these conclusions, he proposes a theory that suggest not just to answer his personal problems, but maybe even offer possible solutions to social issues that affect the society by large. They theorize that the dichotomy of pure and impure altruism was non-existent. Altruistic attitudes and behaviors arise because of a mixture of motivations and (biological) human relations. More importantly, altruism arise when one asks for it. This is how powerful taking down notes can be. It is the first step in enriching our sociological imagination, thus prompt us to identify problems, develop methods, and propose theories. This is how the interludes of intellectual craftsmanship prompt social scientists to understand social processes and events. And as individuals, we possess this power as part of our intellectual craftsmanship. That according to C. W. Mills (1959), “encourages expansion of the categories which we use in our thinking.”

Part of the individual being a reflection of the society is that the society develops the individual. The collective intellectual craftsmanship permits us to form our identities. The beliefs, values, and attitudes we possess are shaped by the existent social norms and values systems within our proximal and distant environment. Therefore, we can say that there is no single reality for everyone. The reality for people living in the tropic regions may be different from the reality of people living in the cold regions. Our environment forces us to adapt, thus create a unique perspective of the world. However, despite these differences, knowledge generated through research by a single or group of individuals has led us to understand the increasing complexities of our humanness. Through research, we were able to develop empathy and see the world from another person’s or group’s point of view. For instance, the reality of Jewish people was different from the reality of Germans during the Nazi regime. The Jews are forced into hiding. They live in constant feelings of terror and anxiety. But as I have mentioned above, our realities have connections. According to C. W. Mills (1959), there is an intricate connection between the journey of our own lives and the course of history, although it is not something we may always be aware of. This connection between realities have illustrated one of the greatest values of all time – our humanity. The works of Varese and Yaish (1998) showed that altruism or the willingness to help others without expecting something in return is the values that connected Germans (rescuers) and Jews (rescues). Moreover, it established

that altruism is more than an evolutionary or motivational values. It is also a moral (*i.e. religious beliefs one upholds*), economic (*i.e. the amount of resources one has*), and social (*i.e. trust of neighbors, safety from authority*) decision. In other words, a person's decision to help should not be reduced to being pure or impure, instead it is a complex process where he takes into consideration his capacity and the possible consequences of his actions in his well-being. Despite this, it is clear that altruistic attitudes and behaviors are a personal and collective values that is rooted in our culture, history, and geography.

Attitudes and Behaviors are Shared within Society

From what I have uttered previously, the individual is complex in itself because we differ in cognition and behaviors. However, our differences are not solely because of our own decisions, but because of the three foundations of civilization: culture, history, and geography. According to C. W. Mills (1959), the things that shape our attitudes and behaviors include social norms, motivations (*i.e. gains*), and the social context in which we live in (*e.g. country, time period, people*). Therefore, culture, history, and geography play a huge part in the formation of our identities and development of character that guide our attitudes and behaviors.

Part of our intellectual craftsmanship is intellectual production. We continuously grow in our heads' files of facts and ideas, from most ambiguous to the most elaborated ones. Looking closer, despite the crystal clear exposition of the cultural value of altruism, there seems to be crucial questions that literatures were unable to discuss or even mention. First, the study aims to make generalizable conclusions about German altruism. However, looking into its participant demographics, the 510 participants (case) was dominated by young (mean age = 27), middle to upper class and educated people. Clearly, there is disparity with the representation of the whole German population as the middle class point of views where the ones accounted for. How about the perspectives of lower-income class, non-educated, biracial, old Germans? What about people with multiple identities? What if their perspectives are nuanced from what the study has found out? Additionally, altruism was believed to be a collectivist cultural values. It is present among societies with high cultural tightness, obedience and respect to authority, and high group cohesion. Then why is it evident to the German population who has an individualist cultural orientation? More importantly, is altruism a culture-specific value or a universal value? What if altruism is a crisis response attitude and behavior only?

These are several questions which are not addressed by the study. However, C. W. Mills stated everything is a work in progress. Nothing is certain because interludes are created whenever there is a new piece of information. This allows humans to look at the world differently after it is presented and scrutinized. This is the beauty of intellectual craftsmanship that every social scientist possesses.

Knowledge requires Creative Co-construction

With everything I have mentioned above, it is clear that research represents our sociological imagination. According to C. W. Mills, sociological imagination is our “capacity to shift from one perspective to another (Mills, 1959).” Through research, we allow ourselves to see other people’s perspectives in the review of related literature, while asserting our own point of view. The dichotomy of altruism into pure and impure is not solely based on the intellectual craftsmanship of one social scientist. It is a collaboration of many scholars having the same interest of knowing the truth about altruistic attitudes and behaviors. Meanwhile, the data collected and discussion provided by the authors deepens our understanding of altruism whether it is consistent or not with past research. This is how knowledge production is a creative co-construction.

We have seen some disparities above regarding the conduct of the study and the literature. However, as what C. W. Mills (1959) have argued, “neither the life of an individual nor the history of society can be understood without understanding both.” As part of the intellectual craftsmanship and the beauty of social sciences, knowledge production is a never ending process. What was considered as a fact today, may be debunked tomorrow. As a social scientist and scholar, it is important to remain critical with what we consume because it influences our understanding of society and the broader historical scene. Additionally, remember that knowledge production affect lives and shape the future. Our lives are a constant writing of history. We need to be careful with whose realities we forward and represent. To see and use our sociological imagination to provide appropriate solutions and alleviate suffering of those who have less. These lessons are what I think I would keep in mind and promise in the endeavors I would partake in the future as a psychology student, professional, and most importantly, a life learner.

References

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